WILDLIFE

JUMBO CRISIS IN INDIA

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India's most comprehensive estimate of its elephant population comes with some sobering news: pachyderm numbers have fallen by 18-25 per cent, from 29,964 in 2017 to 22,446 now (2021-25). The Synchronous All-India Elephant Estimation (SAIEE) 2021–25 report, prepared by the Wildlife Institute of India, the ministry of environment, forest and climate change, and Project Elephant, represents a scientific milestone. For the first time, the non-invasive genetic SECR (spatially explicit capture-recapture) method has been used to estimate jumbo numbers. Field teams trekked across some 666,977 km of forest trails, collecting dung swabs to extract DNA for analysis. The shift in methodology means current numbers cannot be compared with earlier data, but it does establish a 'fresh baseline' for future monitoring.

WHY NUMBERS ARE FALLING

- **With poaching on the wane, fragmented habitats are the main culprits now. This has led to more human-elephant conflict, retaliatory attacks after raids by the pachyderms**
- **Electrocution deaths from high-tension wires, electric fencing. Rail track accidents also rising**

HOW TO TACKLE THE CRISIS

- **Prevent further habitat destruction, secure traditional elephant corridors**
- **Integrate land-use planning with conservation efforts. Incorporate elephant-friendly thresholds**
- **Focus conservation efforts/resources on states with high jumbo numbers, those with high threats**

22,446
2025

(All figures are estimated; 2025 range: 18,255-26,645)